

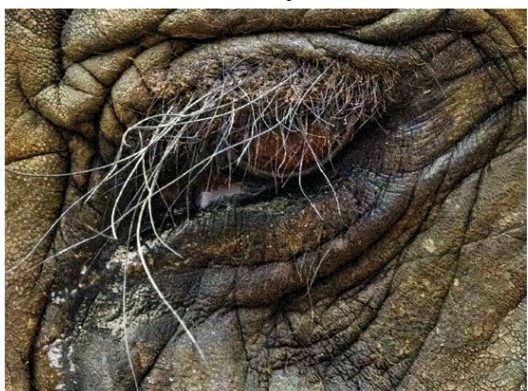
AFRICAN SAVANNA ELEPHANT

Loxodonta africana

A mature male African savanna elephant is larger than any other living land mammal and in exceptional cases can weigh as much as ten tonnes. The head alone can exceed 400 kg (880 lb), including the brain, eyes, trunk, ears, tusks, and teeth. Females are smaller and form strongly bonded herds, comprising a dominant female, close relatives, and their offspring. Bull elephants form less cohesive groups led by older males, but in the breeding season, when they come into musth, they are more solitary and will fight for access to receptive females. Elephants are long lived and may survive well into their 60s.

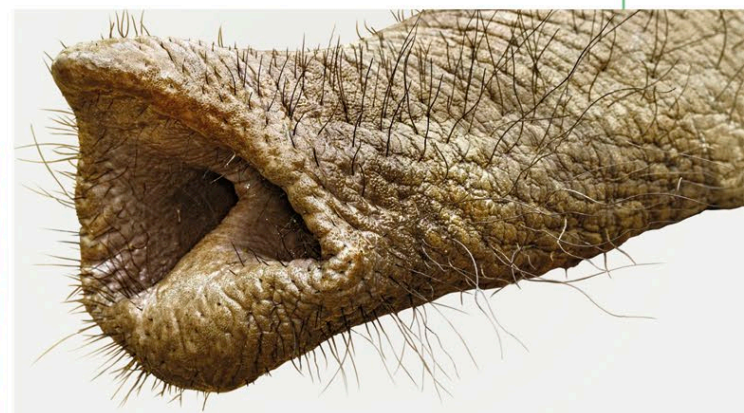
EYE ∨

Long eyelashes protect the small, laterally-positioned eyes, which can see clearly for only about 10 m (33 ft). Other senses compensate for this limitation.



TRUNK SKIN ∨

The trunk has short sensory hairs along its length that enhance its responsiveness to touch.



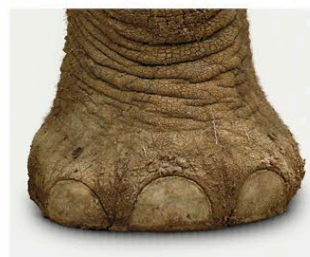
^ FINGER-LIKE TIP

The opposing finger-like projections at the tip of the trunk are extremely sensitive and dextrous. This allows the African savanna elephant to pick up objects as small as a peanut.



EAR >

The large, thin-skinned ears help regulate body temperature. They are also used to communicate moods, such as aggression.



^ FOOT

Elephant feet have sensory receptors along their margins. They pick up low-frequency underground sounds that can travel over long distances.

< TAIL

Elephants swing their tail to deter insects. The air turbulence created prevents them from landing, and any that do are swatted.

musth glands are only found in elephants and are present in both sexes

the tusks are enlarged second incisor teeth

SIZE 2.6–4 m (8½–13 ft)

HABITAT Dry woodland, scrub, and savanna grassland

DISTRIBUTION Mainly E. and S. Africa, south of the Sahara

DIET Leaves, roots, bark, fruits, and seeds

LARGE AND HEAVY >

A bulky body supported by rather straight, columnar legs might suggest the elephant is a slow-moving animal. It can, however, reach speeds of 24kph (15mph) when charging.

large abdominal cavity contains about 19 m (62 ft) of intestines

